

SECTION 5

Giving Feedback

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You're a Leader Now. Not Everyone Is Going to Like You

by Martin G. Moore

As a manager, it's natural to want to be liked and accepted by your team. You want to win people's approval, keep them happy, and demonstrate all the desirable attributes of a great boss.

Even so, as the person in charge, almost everything you do will have the potential to trigger conflict. Consider your core responsibilities: stretching your team to reach higher standards; coaching people one-on-one; setting collective and individual goals; making tough calls; negotiating; drawing out and resolving tensions to unlock diverse thinking.

Most of these tasks will involve some form of conflict, and none of them will go hand in hand with being liked. If you're not comfortable with that, you'll struggle to do your job well and gain the respect of others.

The truth is leadership is hard. It demands that we sometimes do things that are opposite our primordial instincts. We constantly risk not being loved by the masses. It's one of the most difficult psychological barriers to overcome, but ultimately, your job is to deliver results. This means you have to make decisions that not everyone is going to like, and you can only do that if you get comfortable with conflict.

In my experience as a corporate executive and CEO in a number of different industries, I've had the opportunity to coach and mentor leaders at all levels, many of whom were able to overcome conflict aversion to become stronger, more confident leaders.

Confronting Conflict

The best place to start is with your own team. If you can master giving them one-on-one feedback—good or bad—everything else will follow.

The DNA that underpins a high-performing team is high-performing individuals. Bringing out the best in each person will require you to have countless direct, honest, and empathetic conversations. Some leaders never master this. They spend years avoiding confrontation until it's virtually impossible to ignore. This is a career killer that I've seen derail many otherwise outstanding performers.

Right now, there's probably a conversation that you're putting off, that you know deep down you need to have. If you don't want your career to flounder, stop rationalizing and avoiding. Start developing the discipline of providing your team with the feedback they need to succeed.

If you deliver your words with compassion, your team will sense that you have their best interests at heart. Being closely connected to your people in this way is a prerequisite for building trust—and if people trust and respect you, there's nothing you can't say to them. Your mutual ability to have these kinds of conversations will soon become the bedrock of your collective achievements.

The following five lenses can help you shift your mindset and find the inspiration to initiate a potentially trying chat with your team member. The next time you find yourself avoiding, consider looking through them to remind

yourself why you *must* get over your fears and get on with it. This is the first step to building the trait of a great leader: a willingness to do the hard thing when it needs to be done.

Lens 1: You have a duty of care to your people

Everyone deserves competent leadership—it's a right, not a privilege. You are responsible for your people's physical and mental well-being while they're in your charge, and this is a responsibility that you shouldn't take lightly.

If you learn to put yourself in your people's shoes, your duty of care to them will outweigh your fear of giving them critical feedback. Even though it may still be daunting, you'll be more likely to push ahead.

Lens 2: You can't get results from a subpar team

The job of a leader is to build a high-performing team that delivers results, and it's impossible to build a high-performing team unless you can challenge, coach, and confront your people to bring out their best. Strong leaders put their commitment to building team capability and performance above any fear, anxiety, or discomfort they may experience. Remember this the next time you feel hesitant to offer a team member constructive criticism.

Lens 3: Your people deserve the opportunity to improve

It's heartbreaking to see how many people go through their careers without ever receiving the blindingly obvious feedback that would have made a difference. Choosing not to give constructive feedback to your people because you don't want to hurt their feelings or because you fear they will dislike you robs them of the opportunity to improve.

If someone isn't performing, that's one thing, but don't compound the felony by letting them live under the misapprehension that everything is fine if it's not. If you can muster the courage to give them the feedback they need, you'll give them an amazing gift—the opportunity to change the trajectory of their career.

Lens 4: Everyone knows the strong and weak performers

If you allow poor performance to go unchecked, you'll kill the culture. When top performers see poor performance being tolerated, they become disenchanted. Eventually, the good people leave, and mediocrity becomes the norm. Not managing individual performance marks you as a weak leader—and no one likes working for a weak leader.

Lens 5: What if you need to let them go?

Sometimes, when people choose not to meet the required standard, you have to make the tough decision to let them go. Before you go down this path, which is likely to have a significant impact on another human's life, you need to be confident that you've done everything within your power to help them. Giving feedback early and often will give you this confidence.

Respect Before Popularity

As you go into these conversations, let this be your mantra. The sooner you accept that you cannot please everyone, the better.

For every decision you make—and this includes giving tough feedback—there will be someone who thinks you should have made a different one. As a leader it is your job to listen to everyone. Give them the respect you want to receive. But, in the end, all things considered, you do what you believe is right. Although it can be

disconcerting to realize that not everyone agrees, it's also strangely liberating: If you accept that you can't please everybody, it clears the path to do what you think is right, not what's popular.

Popularity doesn't matter. Doing the right thing does.

QUICK RECAP

When you find yourself avoiding giving critical feedback, look through these lenses.

- **Lens 1: You have a duty of care to your people.** This duty will outweigh your fear of delivering feedback.
 - **Lens 2: You can't get results from a subpar team.** Your people can't achieve high performance unless you challenge them to do their best.
 - **Lens 3: Your people deserve the opportunity to improve.** Not giving them constructive feedback robs them of the chance.
 - **Lens 4: Everyone knows the strong and weak performers.** When poor performance is tolerated, mediocrity becomes the norm.
 - **Lens 5: What if you need to let them go?** Be confident that you've done everything to help them first.
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Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, September 16, 2021.

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Mistakes Managers Make When Giving Feedback

by Brooke Vuckovic

Many managers view giving feedback as one of the most challenging and unpleasant parts of their jobs. Critiquing someone's performance can be an emotional, anxiety-inducing experience.

Here's the thing: No one is naturally good at giving feedback. It's a skill that's learned over time with guidance and practice. But as a manager, it's essential that you do learn it—and not just in the context of delivering yearly performance reviews. In fact, many leading companies have been dropping annual performance ratings in favor of more immediate and ongoing conversations. More than ever, real-time critiques are part of daily life for managers.

Fortunately, you can take steps to become better at providing consistent performance feedback. Start by becoming aware of the mistakes you may be making and learning what to do to avoid those pitfalls.

Mistake 1: Not Winning Trust Before Providing Feedback

A manager who gives feedback without first establishing trust is like a director who fails to set the scene before their actors take the stage. In the absence of trust, your direct reports will have a harder time hearing, accepting, and acting on your feedback.

Think about it in the context of receiving feedback from your own boss. If they seem indifferent to your career goals, provide scattered feedback without direction, and try to control your every move, are you going to readily accept and act on the feedback they provide? What about if, instead, they take the time to understand you, share feedback in the context of your aspirations, and give you space to grow and learn?

Solution

The first thing you should do as a manager is to get to know each of your team members—including their career aspirations and goals. In your one-on-one conversations, ask: “What goals are you hoping to achieve in your role over the next six months?” or “How do you see your role evolving over the next year?” Some of your direct reports may be focused on getting promoted, while others may be eager to develop skills that will help them take on higher-profile assignments.

Once context has been established, and you're clear about how you can support your team members' development, you can begin to link your feedback to their goals. For example, you might say, “I know you want to take on more responsibility, so this is an area in which you need more development. One thing you can do better is ...” In those two sentences you go from critic to coach. Showing your direct reports that you care about their growth through your feedback will further help instill their trust in you.

Mistake 2: Avoiding or Delaying Feedback

Given the discomfort of sharing feedback with others, it's not surprising that your first instinct may be to avoid it. When you see an opportunity for giving negative feedback, for example, you may find yourself simply hoping the issue will resolve on its own. Or you may assume it will be easier to wait and deliver your feedback during a structured annual review.

But delaying feedback, or simply waiting for a situation to improve, helps no one. By avoiding these conversations, you're doing a disservice to your direct reports and the overall success of your team.

Solution

Be consistent with your feedback sessions and build them in, rather than waiting until there is an issue to address. For example, if you're giving a direct report an assignment—whether it's something brand new or with higher stakes than their usual responsibilities—add “pulse check” sessions into the calendar for the end of the assignment or when the employee completes certain milestones. If an employee is supposed to win two new accounts, you could set up pulse checks for after the first three meetings, the negotiation, and the closure stages. These scheduled debriefs should include discussing what went well and what could have been done differently (their thoughts first, and then your feedback). By engaging in this exercise, you'll establish a pattern for giving and receiving feedback in real time.

Mistake 3: Overdelivering Feedback ... at the Wrong Time

As the saying goes, feedback is a gift. But too much can be overwhelming.

You must learn how to decide if a piece of feedback is worth giving, or if doing so would hurt the situation more than help it. This can be especially important (and difficult) when it comes to receiving and conveying feedback about your direct reports from others.

Say, for example, your team is managing a conference for your company. As the first day comes to a close, you overhear your supervisor complaining about a few elements of the event. Instead of stopping to consider if the feedback indicates a trend or just the opinion of one loud voice, you decide to deliver it to your team raw and without context. But in doing so, you alienate your team members and undermine your effectiveness as a new leader.

Solution

The solution is discernment. It's your decision whether to share the feedback you receive from others with your direct reports. When you receive feedback for your team, remind yourself of their goals and then filter out any recommendations that won't be useful in helping them improve or reach them.

Using the prior example, let's say you received feedback that the sessions during the first day of the conference ran over the scheduled time limit. Several attendees complained about the ending feeling rushed and not being able to ask questions. That feedback, indicating a consensus of opinion among several people, will help ensure a smoother event in the future. Therefore, it would be worth conveying that feedback to your direct reports. On the other hand, if you receive feedback from one person that they didn't like the topic of a session, you may want to keep that to yourself. The random opinion of one person may not be constructive and could take your team's attention and efforts away from making impactful changes.

You also need to learn when to deliver feedback. While offering feedback promptly helps learning, there is one caveat: When emotions are running high or tanks are running low, it becomes even more important to filter and focus your feedback. For example, day one of a three-day event is *not* the time for a detailed debrief. Rather, it's a good time for focusing on one or maybe two things that might be improved the next day, like technology issues, making sure people can find the display booth, and ensuring that all speakers follow the schedule. A week later,

with all the feedback from audience reactions, satisfaction survey results, and other outcomes measured, a detailed debrief will be more useful. Delaying that detailed feedback will also help to eliminate blame and give you time to brainstorm solutions together as a team.

Mistake 4: Failing to Follow Up

Even if you give feedback at the right time, use the right words, and deliver it from a place of trust, it's all useless if you don't follow up. When you give feedback without circling back, your team members could lose their motivation and may be less likely to follow through on your suggestions. Without a follow-up, you may also not realize that your team is still struggling, or the direction you suggested may not be working for them.

Solution

For feedback to work, it needs to be consistent. After providing feedback, check in with your direct reports to see how they're progressing with their development. It can be as simple as asking, "In our last check-in, we talked about you trying a different approach. How is that working for you?" When your discussions are grounded in context—connecting the dots between feedback and the person's goals and aspirations—they become supportive conversations that promote ongoing learning.

Keep in mind that feedback isn't just criticism. Positive messages demonstrate that you see your team members' efforts and reinforce trust. For example, you could say, "You've been working on refining your visual representation of customer data, and it's very noticeable! You're ready to be part of the next presentation to the division head."

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Awareness of your mistakes will only get you so far—this foundational managerial skill demands repetition and practice. While it may feel uncomfortable or overwhelming at first, once mastered, it will pay dividends throughout your career.

QUICK RECAP

Providing feedback is an essential part of every manager's job to ensure high performance and development. Here are common mistakes to avoid:

- **Not winning trust before providing feedback.** Without trust, your reports will have a harder time hearing, accepting, and acting on your feedback.
 - **Avoiding or delaying feedback.** Instead, be consistent with your feedback sessions.
 - **Overdelivering feedback at the wrong time.** You must decide if a piece of feedback is worth giving and when, or if doing so would hurt the situation more than help it.
 - **Failing to follow up.** Circle back to check in on an individuals' progress.
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Adapted from "Mistakes First-Time Managers Make When Giving Feedback," on hbr.org, September 22, 2023.

How can you approach giving feedback, especially when you're dreading it? Watch this video:



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Why Employees Need Both Recognition and Appreciation

by Mike Robbins

Recognition and appreciation. We often use these words interchangeably and think of them as the same thing. But while they're both important, there's a big difference between them. Leaders who want their teams to thrive and organizations that want to create cultures of engagement, loyalty, and high performance need to understand the distinction.

Recognition is about giving positive feedback based on results or performance. Sometimes this happens in a formal way: an award, a bonus, a promotion, a raise. Sometimes recognition is given more informally: a verbal thank-you, a handwritten note. All of these methods can be meaningful, especially if they're done in a timely and genuine way. They're also motivating and exciting—everyone wants their good work to be applauded.

But there are some limits to recognition. First, it's performance-based, so it's conditional. Second, it's based on the past, so it's about what people have already done. Third, it's scarce. There's a limited amount of recognition to go around—everyone can't get a bonus or be mentioned by name in a memo—and it can be stressful when many people are vying for a finite amount of praise. Fourth, it generally has to come from the top. Many organizations have set up programs that allow peers to highlight each other's efforts, but the major forms of recognition (promotions, raises, and so on) are usually given by senior leaders.

And while recognition that includes monetary compensation can be great, researchers from the London School of Economics found that financial incentives can actually backfire when it comes to motivating employees. According to an analysis of 51 experiments, "these incentives may reduce an employee's natural inclination to complete a task and derive pleasure from doing so."

Appreciation, on the other hand, is about acknowledging a person's inherent value. The point isn't their accomplishments. It's their worth as a colleague and a human being.

In simple terms, recognition is about what people do; appreciation is about who they are.

This distinction matters because recognition and appreciation are given for different reasons. Even when people succeed, inevitably there will be failures and challenges along the way; depending on the project, there may not even be tangible results to point to. If you focus solely on praising positive outcomes, on *recognition*, you miss out on lots of opportunities to connect with and support your team members—to *appreciate* them.

Oprah Winfrey spoke about this in a powerful way when she gave a commencement speech at Harvard in 2013:

I have to say that the single most important lesson I learned in 25 years talking every single day to people was that there's a common denominator in our human experience.... The common denominator that I found in every single interview is we want to be validated. We want to be understood. I've done over 35,000 interviews in my career. And as soon as that camera shuts off, everyone always turns to me and inevitably, in their own way, asks this question: "Was that OK?" I heard it from President Bush. I heard it from

President Obama. I've heard it from heroes and from housewives. I've heard it from victims and perpetrators of crimes. I even heard it from Beyoncé in all of her Beyoncé-ness.... [We] all want to know one thing: "Was that OK?" "Did you hear me?" "Do you see me?" "Did what I say mean anything to you?"

What Oprah was talking about is appreciation. And when we show appreciation to our colleagues, customers, managers, and partners, we're more likely to build trust and connect.

Here are a few simple ways to show appreciation for those around you:

Listen. One of the best things you can do for the people you work with is also one of the simplest: Put down your phone, turn away from your computer, and genuinely listen to them.

Tell people what you value about them. Doing this proactively—not because someone did something great or because you want something from them—is an incredibly powerful gift. It can positively affect how your colleagues feel about themselves, your relationship with them, and the culture of the team.

Check in. There's a quote I like that is often attributed to Teddy Roosevelt: "People don't care how much you know until they know how much you care." No matter who said it, it's such a great reminder. Check in with the people you work with. Genuinely asking how they're doing and what they're challenged by right now can show them that you care.

Showing appreciation for employees is especially important if you're a manager. In Glassdoor's Employee Appreciation Survey, 53% of people said feeling more appreciation from their boss would help them stay longer at their company—even though 68% said their boss already shows them enough appreciation.¹ The lesson? More is better.

Great leaders have to successfully focus on and cultivate both appreciation and recognition. And all of us benefit from understanding this distinction in business (and in life). Recognition is appropriate and necessary when it's earned and deserved. Appreciation, however, is important all the time.

QUICK RECAP

Recognition is about giving positive feedback based on results or performance. Appreciation is about acknowledging a person's inherent value. Employees need both, but you have the power to give appreciation every day. Here's how:

- **Listen.** Put down your phone, turn away from your computer, and give them your full attention.
 - **Tell people what you value about them.** Doing so can positively affect how your colleagues feel about themselves, your relationship with them, and the culture of the team.
 - **Check in.** Genuinely asking how your employees are doing and what they're challenged by right now can show them that you care.
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Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, November 12, 2019 (product #H059FN).

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Managing an Underperformer Who Thinks They're Doing Great

by Liz Kislik

When you become a manager, your hope is that everyone on your team will be a star performer. But unfortunately, that's not always the case. People underperform at work for a variety of reasons—from not understanding a project's objectives, to not feeling motivated or valued, to not having the support they need to succeed. As a leader, it's your responsibility to identify what's holding them back and help them find ways to improve.

Here are five things you can do to help underperformers move forward.

Learn More About the Underperformer

If you don't understand an underperformer's goals and interests, it will be impossible for you to determine why they're falling short in their role. Even if this person has been on your team for a while, people's motivations change as circumstances evolve. Set aside time to directly ask what's currently driving them. This is especially important if you're working in a hybrid or remote environment, where you may not have the benefit of casual, in-person contact to pick up details about family, hobbies, or past work successes.

You should also check in about their preferences regarding how they work. For example, do they prefer strict deadlines to structure their often-interrupted workdays or more flexible deadlines to help them deal with home obligations like child- or eldercare? Based on their answers, modify your management approach to match their needs. For instance, you might learn that they miss working side by side with colleagues and would perform better if they were assigned to projects that involved more regular interaction.

Revisit Your Expectations

Once you better understand the underperformer's motivations, you should also reflect on what you want most from the employee, and why you feel you're not getting it. Start by reviewing your recent directives and whether your communications about what's expected have been clear and consistent from the beginning. This is something you do with underperformers in any context, but if you work in a remote or hybrid environment, it's even more important to ask yourself whether your statements have been ambiguous. Part of this process is separating out whether your dissatisfaction is with their work products or with the way they deliver.

If their style or approach is the problem, check to see if you're expecting them to work the way you do. If that's the case, let go of those expectations and dispassionately assess their real strengths and capacities for contributing to the team's work.

If you suspect the underperformer’s difficulties come from insufficient experience, specific skill deficits, or a lack of business or organizational acumen, consider whether they need training or to partner with a more experienced colleague.

Level with Them and Be Specific

Once you better understand the underperformer (and your expectations), you need to provide direct feedback. Many people who aren’t doing well have a vague feeling that something is wrong, but don’t really know which of their behaviors isn’t working. For example, telling a team leader that they need to be a better listener doesn’t help them understand specifically what they need to do differently. It’s much more helpful to explain that when they turn away during video conferences or change the subject while team members are speaking, the team loses trust and confidence in them. The feedback gives them the opportunity to actively practice modifying those behaviors.

Help Them Learn How to Improve Their Own Performance

As much as possible, use questions to encourage them to self-diagnose and to project into their own future: “How will this experience set you up to do better in the future?” I often ask coaching clients, “Why do you think I’m asking you this?” to encourage them to reach their own conclusions, rather than telling them what I have observed. Giving them an opportunity for self-discovery can provide a kind of aha moment that directly telling them your thoughts won’t. This will also help you avoid micromanaging, which is a significant temptation when you’re trying to be extremely clear about expectations.

Stay in Close-Enough Contact

It’s on you as a manager to stay in regular touch with underperformers and to keep them in the loop. Don’t assume that no news is good news. After you’ve given an underperformer candid feedback, if they don’t hear from you, they may start to worry that you’re ignoring them because you’ve written them off, and their performance can deteriorate further. Schedule regular meetings to talk about their progress.

If you’ve asked them to keep you up to date on their progress, make clear how you want them to do that. If they tend to use email, but you’re awash in email and respond better to texts or Slack messages, tell them that. And don’t rely only on video meetings, where the lack of true eye contact can make it seem like you’re getting nonverbal clues when you’re not. If you’re concerned that you’re not getting a good read on your remote team member’s state of mind, plan to have at least some of your interactions by phone and listen carefully. The tone of their voice may give you more clues about what needs intervention.

Firing with Compassion

by Joel Peterson

When an underperformer isn't receptive to feedback or isn't making improvements, there may come a time where you need to let that employee go. It's a difficult decision, and an even more difficult conversation. Here's how to navigate the process with fairness and empathy.

Prepare and Practice

Rehearsing for difficult conversations may be the single best way to prepare for them. Before entering a termination discussion, I engage in a series of self-talk exercises designed to reinforce the necessity of the action and put myself in the right mindset. Some of them emphasize the need to act with grace and gravitas. (*Letting this person go is one of my most important tasks. I will do it with the utmost sensitivity.*) I also remind myself that as a manager, I deserve some of the blame for the person's failure, owing to poor hiring or coaching. (*This results from my mistakes as well as theirs.*) And, to avoid becoming defensive, I focus on the optimal outcome. (*I want to help*

this person find a place where they can maximize their potential—a place that better fits their skills, personality, ambitions, and style of working.)

Deliver the Message Immediately and Clearly

When you've decided to let someone go, schedule a meeting and deliver the message within the first 30 seconds of sitting down: "We've decided to make a change/terminate your position/replace you." To drag it out—which many managers do out of discomfort at delivering painful news—invites misunderstanding and awkwardness. It also gets in the way of moving promptly to next steps—organizing the departure in a way that is most helpful to the employee and least disruptive to the organization.

Don't Overexplain the Decision

A termination meeting is a time to communicate a decision—not to debate it, defend it, or negotiate it. It's natural for people being fired to seek more information—to repeatedly ask variants of the question *Why?* You needn't offer an elaborate answer; instead, give a simple explanation for the decision—whether it's due to performance issues, needed cutbacks, or the elimination of roles or functions. If you've done a reasonable job of providing feedback, coaching, and context on the dynamics of your workplace before this conversation, the employee already has sufficient information. If the person insists on defending themselves, avoid the temptation to engage.

Be Human

Good bosses aren't automatons. They should recognize that employees who are being fired will feel an unpleasant mix of emotions. They should listen patiently to any reactions and carefully calibrate their responses. It's natural to feel sympathy or regret that you're firing someone, but expressing those emotions may encourage an attempt to leverage sympathy and debate the decision. As they deal with their own emotions, bosses must recognize the difference between empathy and compassion (which are useful in this context) and sympathy or sorrow (which can be counterproductive).

Excerpted from "Firing with Compassion," in *Harvard Business Review*, March–April 2020 (product #R2002L).

Managing underperformers isn't easy, but using specific, road-tested techniques to help them improve will strengthen not only their performance but their relationship with you as well.

QUICK RECAP

Underperformers need guidance on how they can get back on track and improve. Here are five things you can do:

- **Learn more about the underperformer.** Aim to understand their goals and interests, so you can determine why they're falling short.
- **Revisit your expectations.** Reflect on what you want from the employee, and why you feel you're not getting it.
- **Level with them and be specific.** Give them direct feedback, so they can modify their behaviors.
- **Help them learn how to improve their own performance.** Use questions to encourage them to self-diagnose and reach their own conclusions.
- **Stay in close-enough contact.** Schedule regular meetings to talk about their progress.

Adapted from "5 Tips for Managing an Underperformer—Remotely," on hbr.org, July 22, 2020 (product #H05QUZ).

Firing an underperformer can be challenging and nerve-racking. Watch this video to learn how to do it with compassion:

